

5.6 Assessment criteria for composition

Holistic assessment criterion

Holistic (AO2)		
36–40	Outstanding	Impressive and imaginative in style, ideas and development. Complete (or almost complete) control of compositional methods and techniques used. Sense of musical wholeness with no passage sub-standard.
31–35	Excellent	Convincing throughout in style, ideas and development. Good control of compositional methods and techniques used. Any errors and/or misjudgements are marginal.
26–30	Confident	Convincing for most of the time in style, ideas and development. Some control of (perhaps a narrow range) compositional methods and techniques. Some errors and/or misjudgements, but too few to have a big impact.
21–25	Competent	Generally secure in style and ideas, but development may be limited. Some effective control of (probably a narrow range) compositional methods and techniques. Some errors and misjudgements, but the piece still has some direction and flow.
16–20	Adequate	A serious attempt but probably some inconsistent/immature handling of style and ideas. Some effective use of (probably a narrow range) compositional methods and techniques. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems begin to be obtrusive, but much of the piece still holds together.
11–15	Basic	Positive features are fairly few with inconsistent/immature handling of style and ideas. Basic use of (perhaps just a few) compositional methods and techniques. Errors, misjudgements and technical problems are obtrusive.
6–10	Limited	Positive features are few. A few encouraging signs, but considerable difficulties with a weak end product in most areas. Perhaps under the required length.
1–5	Poor	Positive features are very few, being heavily outweighed by errors, misjudgements and technical problems. In practice, a mark in the 1–5 band is appropriate only for work which is seriously under the required length and/or difficulty or too incomplete to be marked the using five detailed assessment criteria.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Detailed assessment criteria

Criterion 1: Quality of ideas and outcome (compulsory for composing and technical study)

Overall security and effectiveness of materials and the technical processes used to develop them. Extent to which the piece meets the specification in terms of duration.

Criterion 1: Quality of ideas and outcome (compulsory for Section A and B) (AO2)		
8	Outstanding	Mature and exciting ideas. Ambitious and highly creative realisation of ideas throughout — highly imaginative.
7	Excellent	Very convincing ideas. Ambitious and creative realisation of ideas throughout.
6	Confident	Generally convincing ideas. Ambitious and creative realisation of ideas, with only occasional weaknesses.
5	Competent	Broadly satisfying ideas. Broadly satisfying end product with a few weaknesses not seriously detracting from the overall impression.
4	Adequate	Some useful ideas. Serious attempt, despite some obvious technical weaknesses, or mechanical end product.
3	Basic	A few workable ideas. Reasonable attempt to use and develop ideas, but marred by technical problems or brevity.
2	Limited	Ideas limited and/or very few. Limited sense of assurance and seriously compromised by lack of sophistication and/or brevity.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of competence. Seriously under-length.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 2:
Coherence
(compulsory)**

Structure: sense of wholeness (including relationship between component parts and the whole), and structure of individual sections. Balance of unity and variety.

Criterion 2: Coherence (compulsory) (AO2)		
8	Outstanding	Imaginative, with sophisticated and/or complex structure. Completely convincing balance between unity and variety.
7	Excellent	A sense of wholeness, with sophisticated and/or complex structure. Convincing balance between unity and variety.
6	Confident	Some feeling of wholeness, with sophisticated and/or complex structure. Generally convincing balance between unity and variety, despite a few minor misjudgements.
5	Competent	Satisfactory use of basic, balanced structures. Some balance between unity and variety, despite minor misjudgements.
4	Adequate	Serious attempt at using basic, balanced structures, but perhaps repetitive, predictable or formulaic. Serious attempt to create variety, but repetitive or lacking contrast in parts.
3	Basic	Basic sense of structure, but repetitive, predictable and/or formulaic. Some attempt to create variety.
2	Limited	A limited sense of structure, design and balance, lacking flow and contrast.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of structure, design or balance.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 3: Forces and Textures (compulsory)

Handling of forces (ie the chosen voice(s) and/or instrument(s)) and timbres — including use of ICT where appropriate; Handling of ensemble (where candidate uses more than one voice or instrument). Choice and management of textures.

Criterion 3: Forces and textures (compulsory) (AO2)		
8	Outstanding	Imaginative with full understanding and thoughtful exploitation of chosen forces. Imaginative use of an appropriate range of textures.
7	Excellent	Very good understanding and exploitation of chosen forces. A range of appropriate textures handled very successfully.
6	Confident	Generally effective writing with some attempt to exploit chosen forces. Range of textures handled securely with only a few minor misjudgements.
5	Competent	Broadly satisfying writing, although not much attempt to extend chosen forces. Textures generally well handled, but perhaps lacking in variety.
4	Adequate	Rather functional treatment of chosen forces. Textures reasonably well handled, but probably lacking in variety.
3	Basic	Some basic ability to write for chosen forces, but perhaps with some unidiomatic writing. Textures sometimes misjudged and/or unvaried.
2	Limited	Limited awareness of vocal and/or instrumental idiom or texture (probably with some unsingable/unplayable material).
1	Poor	Very little evidence of good judgement in handling forces and textures.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 4:
Harmony
(optional)**

Choice of chords and chord progressions and dissonance treatment. In tonal music, choice and handling of modulations.

Criterion 4: Harmony (optional) (AO2)		
8	Outstanding	Mature and sophisticated use of appropriate harmonic progressions. Enterprising use of tonality and modulation.
7	Excellent	Very convincing use of appropriate harmonic progressions. Effective use of tonality and modulation.
6	Confident	Convincing use of appropriate harmonic progressions, despite one or two misjudgements or limitations. Sound use of tonality and modulation, but perhaps unenterprising.
5	Competent	Competent control of harmonic progressions for the most part, despite some technical weaknesses or eccentricities. Sound, or generally sound, use of tonality and modulation, but probably a little unenterprising.
4	Adequate	Some reasonable understanding of the more elementary harmonic progressions, but technical weaknesses are sometimes obtrusive. Some understanding of tonality and modulation, but little enterprise.
3	Basic	Some understanding of basic harmonic progressions some of the time, but compromised by fairly frequent uncomfortable moments and misjudgements. Probably little success with tonality and modulation.
2	Limited	Limited understanding and control of harmony and tonality, with many uncomfortable moments and misjudgements.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of harmony and tonal understanding and control.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

Criterion 5: Melody (optional) The horizontal organisation of the music: the melodic construction (including any motivic working) and shape, and the security of the part writing.

Criterion 5: Melody (optional) (A02)		
8	Outstanding	Distinctive and well-shaped melodic lines throughout. Part-writing elegant and flowing throughout.
7	Excellent	Convincing and well-shaped melodic lines throughout. Part writing efficient and successful apart from marginal error(s).
6	Confident	Generally convincing and well-shaped melodic lines. Part writing successful apart from some minor errors.
5	Competent	Generally successful melodic lines, but sometimes lacking in shape and/or contrast. Part writing generally successful, but with a small number of obvious errors.
4	Adequate	Reasonably successful melodic lines, but at times stiff or formulaic. Part writing broadly successful, but with some significant errors.
3	Basic	Some awareness of how to build melodic lines, but generally stiff and/or formulaic. Part writing compromised by many errors.
2	Limited	Melodic lines seriously restricted by lack of shape and/or direction. Part writing seriously compromised by many errors.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of competence in melodic construction and part-writing.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	

**Criterion 6:
Rhythm (optional)**

Interest, effectiveness and variety of rhythmic elements (which *may* include syncopation and such devices as cross-rhythm). In a popular song, criterion 6 may apply to rhythmic articulation of chord progressions and/or riffs and to management of backing tracks, particularly drums and percussion.

Criterion 6: Rhythm (optional) (AO2)		
8	Outstanding	Distinctive and creative use of rhythm throughout, providing a sense of vitality. Rhythms are imaginatively varied and always well controlled.
7	Excellent	Very convincing use of rhythm throughout, providing a sense of vitality. Rhythms well varied and always well controlled.
6	Confident	Generally very convincing use of rhythm, with some sense of vitality, but occasional weaknesses or misjudgements. Rhythms appropriately varied and usually well controlled.
5	Competent	Rhythmic interest is sustained for the most part, but some inconsistency or insecurity is apparent. Some rhythmic variety appropriate to the style.
4	Adequate	Some rhythmic interest and development, but often unsubtle and perhaps repetitive and lacking in variety.
3	Basic	Some basic rhythmic interest, but many passages dull and/or unvaried.
2	Limited	Some limited rhythmic interest, but mostly dull and/or unvaried and/or lacking control.
1	Poor	Very little evidence of rhythmic interest, coherence or competence.
0	No positive features can be clearly identified.	